

THE 50 MOST EXPENSIVE LESSONS

Each one cost somebody a project, a client, or a career to learn. Each one is attributed and linked to the episode where it was said. Read them here, or get the one-page-each version by email below.

01

DOCUMENTATION & RISK EP 045

Every email you send is a potential Exhibit 12. State facts, never opinions or conclusions.

A 25-year-old PM's five emails asking 'are we still using the bad stuff?' ended up on a courtroom projector in a \$30 million dispute.

GARRETT MOTT • CONSTRUCTION TRIAL LAWYER, HENNIGH LAW

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COMMUNICATION EP 054

Lead with the answer. 'This part is behind because of X, here is what we do about it.' Then earn the Gantt chart.

Most project updates are structured like a murder mystery building to a reveal. Owners want the headline first; the detail comes only when someone asks.

LIBBY MAGLIOLO • FOUNDER, THE SLIDE MASTER

03

CAREER

EP 005

The company will always do what is best for the company, so you must do what is best for you and your family.

Mitch calls this realization the turning point in his relationship with his career. Never bleed for a company the way it will not bleed for you.

MITCH MCDONALD · GENERAL SUPERINTENDENT, XL
CONSTRUCTION

04

BUSINESS MODEL

EP 041

Nobody builds 30 percent cheaper on a cost-plus contract. Adoption fails on incentives, not technology.

Billing models reward hours, not outcomes, so a contractor has no reason to deploy efficiency tech that shrinks the billable base.

KP REDDY · MANAGING PARTNER, SHADOW VENTURES

05

TECH ADOPTION

EP 053

Deliberately recruit your loudest known detractor into the pilot so objections surface before the enterprise rollout.

Surface the objections early and fix them with the vendor while it is still cheap, rather than discovering them across 120 people later.

ELLIOT CHRISTIANSEN · SVP OPERATIONS, CLEVELAND
CONSTRUCTION

06

AI

EP 028

Only automate a task that is both repetitive and annoying. If it is not annoying, let your people keep doing it.

AI will not get good at non-repetitive work, and non-annoying work is what people actually want to do.

DR. SARAH BUCHNER • FOUNDER AND CEO, TRUNK TOOLS

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DOCUMENTATION & RISK

EP 045

Daily logs written the same day are admissible gold. Documentation created after a dispute starts has almost no credibility.

Courts admit routine contemporaneous records under the business records exception. One super's meticulous logs caught a sub's invoice fraud and ended it with a letter.

GARRETT MOTT • CONSTRUCTION TRIAL LAWYER, HENNIGH LAW

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COMMUNICATION

EP 043

If you send the problem email to 25 people, nobody owns it. Name one person or it will not get done.

On large projects everyone assumes someone else is handling it. Named individual accountability is the only fix he has found.

WES JUERGENS • REGIONAL SUPERINTENDENT

09

SCHEDULING

EP 055

Write the commissioning schedule assuming it will be cut, because every week and dollar lost upstream gets taken from the end.

Base build loses two weeks, pull it from commissioning. Budget loses a million, pull it from commissioning. By startup you are a dollar late and a day short.

TIM SMITH • DIRECTOR OF COMMISSIONING, QTS DATA CENTERS

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BUSINESS MODEL

EP 047

Three percent margin turned over twelve billing cycles is a thirty percent return on capital. Pitch against that, not the margin.

On a \$100M project with about \$15M of working capital, productivity software aimed at the 3 percent is aimed at the wrong economics.

AARON ANDERSON • FORMER DIRECTOR OF INNOVATION, SWINERTON

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SAFETY

EP 024

An owner who can explain exactly what changed after a fatality may be safer than a contractor with a clean record.

No single prequalification data point should disqualify. A risk signal should trigger a conversation about what the company learned.

DAVID TIBBETTS • CHIEF SAFETY OFFICER, HIGHWIRE

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BUILDING & SELLING TECH

EP 037

Tell the customer what your product will not do before they find out on a jobsite. Honesty outsells features.

Decades of overpromising vendors have construction workers' shields permanently up, so stated limits are the only thing that earns trust.

MARK FLY • PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION
TECH ADVISOR

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DOCUMENTATION & RISK

EP 025

Zero RFIs on a project is a red flag that nobody asked the right questions, not a win to brag about.

Did you actually have line of sight to your risk profile before field execution? RFI quality, not count, is the signal.

ALEX BELKOFER • SENIOR DIRECTOR OF VDC, MCCARTHY
BUILDING COMPANIES

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TECH ADOPTION

EP 040

Never introduce a new tool and a new process in the same rollout. One is change management; both is a multi-year slog.

Granite maps every candidate solution against existing processes first, specifically to keep change management to one variable.

AARON MCCLELLAN • CONSTRUCTION TECHNOLOGY
MANAGER, GRANITE CONSTRUCTION

15

WORKFORCE

EP 034

One retiring veteran takes five new hires to replace. The real labor shortage is knowledge leaving, not bodies missing.

Roughly 400,000 workers retire annually against about 100,000 apprentice completions. The productivity gap is what kills a crew, not the headcount gap.

ANGELO SUNTRES • DIRECTOR OF OPERATIONS, MATINA

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FIELD LEADERSHIP

EP 005

The skills flip at general superintendent. Senior super is 80 percent technical; general super is 80 percent soft skills.

The skills that got you promoted are nearly the inverse of what the next job needs. The job becomes guiding the collective mass of trades, not directing.

MITCH MCDONALD • GENERAL SUPERINTENDENT, XL
CONSTRUCTION

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OWNERS

EP 038

Help the electrician solve the problem on site today and he will not hit you with a change order tomorrow.

Working with a trade to avoid ripping out work creates reciprocity that quietly eliminates future change orders.

STEVE LITTLE • DIRECTOR OF FACILITIES AND
ENGINEERING, THE FRESH MARKET

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TECH ADOPTION

EP 022

Distrust any vendor claim of hours saved per week. Those are hours 41 to 50, not the hours that matter.

With two to four year project lifespans, real pilot metrics take years, and vendors who oversell to get in the door guarantee disappointment on the job.

JOHN RIGGS · SENIOR PROJECT MANAGER, SUFFOLK

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AI

EP 035

The real AI risk is not security. It is someone shipping the first draft as the final draft.

Corporate AI policies obsess over data leakage while the actual damage comes from people treating the tool as an easy button and skipping review.

HUGH SEATON · FOUNDER, THE LINK

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DOCUMENTATION & RISK

EP 042

You cannot fix a bad buy. Scope missed at buyout comes straight out of margin with no way to recover it.

Buyout is the highest-stakes irreversible moment in construction.

CHARLES MA · FOUNDER AND CEO, SCOREBOARD AI

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CAREER

EP 052

Finishing on schedule and budget only buys you the right to bid the next one. The career gets built in moments not in the contract.

The relationships that carry a PM or super come from small, unscripted moments with the client.

SEAN JOHNSON · FOUNDER, MADISON CONSULTING SERVICES

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CAREER

EP 001

Never burn a bridge in commercial construction. You will work with the same people again wearing different hard hats.

Houston is the fourth-largest city in the country and a small world. Crews and managers cross paths across projects and companies for decades.

WES JUERGENS • SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, AUSTIN COMMERCIAL

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BUSINESS MODEL

EP 033

The GC that can bid its CM fee at zero wins, because the margin lives in supply, insurance, and equipment.

Turner's SourceBlue, insurance brokerage, and equipment rentals make the fee a loss leader. A GC stuck doing a little of everything will fail.

VICTOR MUCHIRI • GROWTH LEAD, BUILD VISION

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SCHEDULING

EP 019

Missed submittal dates are the earliest reliable warning of schedule delay. Track them before you track anything else.

Submittal adherence is the single best leading indicator, but one-by-one workflows push teams to Excel, which destroys the indicator's reliability.

JOE WILSON • FOUNDER AND CEO, PROJEXION

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COMMUNICATION

EP 054

Raw data handed to a decision maker is not help. It is work you were supposed to do and pushed onto them.

Saying 'twelve percent over budget due to this reason' is the job. The spreadsheet is not.

LIBBY MAGLIOLO · FOUNDER, THE SLIDE MASTER

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BUILDING & SELLING TECH

EP 041

Sell construction tech like porta potties: show up on one project with donuts, demo, close it on site, drive to the next.

Tech is not spec'd into the project any more than porta potties are. Chasing enterprise agreements without enterprise features is how startups stall.

KP REDDY · MANAGING PARTNER, SHADOW VENTURES

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WORKFORCE

EP 030

Do not automate the tasks that train your people. The PE walking the site with a camera is learning the job.

Mundane tasks build muscle memory. A photo robot removes the development the PE was getting from the walk. Which tasks to protect is a deliberate decision.

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI · VP OF DIGITAL SOLUTIONS,
SKANSKA USA

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SAFETY

EP 024

Before blaming a worker's choice, prove the work was planned, the equipment was there, and the training and time existed.

Exhaust systemic failures first. Only after convincing yourself of all of those can an individual factor even be considered.

DAVID TIBBETTS · CHIEF SAFETY OFFICER, HIGHWIRE

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FIELD LEADERSHIP

EP 003

If you are not doing concrete lift drawings and MEP coordination before a pour, you are leaving risk on a 16-hour activity you cannot undo.

Nothing moves a job faster than a concrete pour, and nothing is harder to fix. Concrete planning is VDC's highest-leverage work on any job.

JACK DESLOGE · SR. VDC MANAGER, VIATECHNIK

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TECH ADOPTION

EP 053

Require usage dashboards from every vendor, because people will tell you they use the tool when the data says zero.

A superintendent claimed he had asked the Q&A tool twelve questions. The dashboard showed none. Accountability needs data, not self-report.

ELLIOT CHRISTIANSEN · SVP OPERATIONS, CLEVELAND CONSTRUCTION

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DOCUMENTATION & RISK

EP 055

Forty-five checklists completed within two minutes of each other is a pencil-whipping signature the data will expose later.

Pencil-whipped Level 2 checklists cascade into Level 3 and Level 4 delays. It is almost always ignorance rather than malice, so the fix is mentoring.

TIM SMITH · DIRECTOR OF COMMISSIONING, QTS DATA CENTERS

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OWNERS

EP 029

Pricing preconstruction too cheap can lose you the job. One owner rejected a GC for exactly that reason.

Owners now read precon as value rather than a free loss leader. Being the cheapest signaled the least effort.

JEREMY CRUMLEY · PRECONSTRUCTION DIRECTOR, BALFOUR BEATTY

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CAREER

EP 040

Create value for the person two levels above you and advancement takes care of itself.

Career advice carried from Special Forces into construction: think about your boss's boss and make your work visibly useful to them.

AARON MCCLELLAN · CONSTRUCTION TECHNOLOGY MANAGER, GRANITE CONSTRUCTION

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TECH ADOPTION

EP 013

Do not bring in another point solution unless it eliminates two or three existing ones. Otherwise you just added a login.

The industry is littered with purpose-built apps for the 150 processes on a project, and every extra one adds noise and data bottlenecks.

HANNU LINDBERG · TECHNOLOGY LEADER, DPR
CONSTRUCTION

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AI

EP 056

When you try to automate a process you discover how much unpriced judgment the 'not that bright' guy was adding.

Pulling a human out of a process trades quality for new risk nobody budgeted. The embedded intelligence only shows up once it is gone.

HUGH SEATON · FOUNDER, THE LINK

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SAFETY

EP 043

If the GC super walks the site with his harness strap undone, every trade will too. Injuries trace back to the example you set.

Quality and safety culture flow from the GC superintendent's own behavior. The goal state is a laborer calling out the super for missing gloves.

WES JUERGENS · REGIONAL SUPERINTENDENT

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BUILDING & SELLING TECH

EP 017

If your tool is harder than the hand signature it replaces, crews revert, and everybody in their network hears about it.

Weeks of training plus an unkept promise sends users back to the old way, and the lost trust is nearly impossible to recover in a relationship-driven industry.

JACKIE GUILBAULT • PRODUCT MARKETING MANAGER,
DOCUMENT CRUNCH

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FIELD LEADERSHIP

EP 021

Running 400 adults at 6am as a dictatorship will fail. People only listen when they are part of the conversation.

Daily coordination of hundreds of workers works because they are treated as participants, not subordinates. Command and control is rewarded culturally but is less effective.

CHRIS MASSE • SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, ELLISDON

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DOCUMENTATION & RISK

EP 019

Hit only 25 percent of critical path milestones for eight straight months and you have forfeited any claim to a time extension.

On a \$200M project the contractor kept saying 'we'll be fine' until admitting a month of delay three months from completion. The pattern itself became the owner's case.

JOE WILSON • FOUNDER AND CEO, PROJEXION

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OWNERS

EP 027

On the owner side you do not call the shots. You ask leading questions until the GC arrives at the solution itself.

The presumption that owners command is a fallacy. Influence, and respect for the GC's means and methods, is how the work gets done.

TIM STRAUB • SENIOR TECHNICAL PROGRAM MANAGER,
GOOGLE

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BUILDING & SELLING TECH

EP 037

Put field practitioners on your advisory board, not just VPs, or you will build for the person who signs and not the one who uses.

The people who detect BS are the ones who walk the site daily.

MARK FLY • PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION
TECH ADVISOR

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TECH ADOPTION

EP 011

Field tech does not save you months on the schedule. It gives you your time back and real data when a dispute lands.

The honest ROI is the superintendent's personal time plus defensible records in a conflict. Expecting schedule compression sets up disappointment.

CHRIS MASSE • SENIOR SUPERINTENDENT, ELLISDON

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BUSINESS MODEL

EP 007

Prefab is a manufacturing business, not construction in a warehouse, and running it with a construction mindset is how you get burned.

Manufacturing processes, work instructions, and controlled environments demand a paradigm shift from field habits. He admits he did not appreciate the difference at first.

ANDREW RENER • EXECUTIVE, ARCHITECTURAL METALS

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SCHEDULING

EP 049

Put model due, signed off, shop drawings in, and approved for install in the field schedule and track them like a bottom-out date.

VDC milestones that live outside the super's schedule slip silently and eat field float.

WALLY CASTRO • SUPERINTENDENT, BERNARDS

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AI

EP 030

An LLM does not know it is wrong and wants to please you, so it will build your confidence on the wrong path.

Confirmation bias instead of course correction: a specific operational hazard for anyone checking their judgment against a chatbot.

MICHAEL ZEPPIERI • VP OF DIGITAL SOLUTIONS,
SKANSKA USA

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WORKFORCE

EP 037

Experienced workers' knowledge is walking out the door and there are roughly five years left to capture it digitally.

The urgency is the retirement clock, not the technology.

MARK FLY • PRODUCT EVANGELIST AND CONSTRUCTION
TECH ADVISOR

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COMMUNICATION

EP 038

Walk the constructability with the foreman face to face. A short email is where a generation hides from hard conversations.

Technology gets used as a buffer against accountability, because challenging someone over email is easier than in person.

STEVE LITTLE • DIRECTOR OF FACILITIES AND
ENGINEERING, THE FRESH MARKET

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SCHEDULING

EP 046

The schedule is the plan. Perfect RFIs and submittals cannot save a job where nobody trusts or is aligned to it.

A schedule the team does not believe in is worse than none. Fix plan trust before buying any other PM tool.

FRANCO GIAQUINTO • CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, OUTBUILD

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CAREER

EP 047

If you are doing the innovator's job right, today could be your last day. You cannot protect your job and ask hard questions.

Risk tolerance, including willingness to be fired, belongs in the job description. He applies the diagnosis to the whole industry.

AARON ANDERSON • FORMER DIRECTOR OF INNOVATION,
SWINERTON

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FIELD LEADERSHIP

EP 007

It is not the guy in the trailer that builds the job. Make young PMs lay block and walk steel so they respect the craft.

The Building Skills program forced young project managers to do trade work to understand what makes a 20-year plasterer's work look effortless.

ANDREW RENER • EXECUTIVE, ARCHITECTURAL METALS